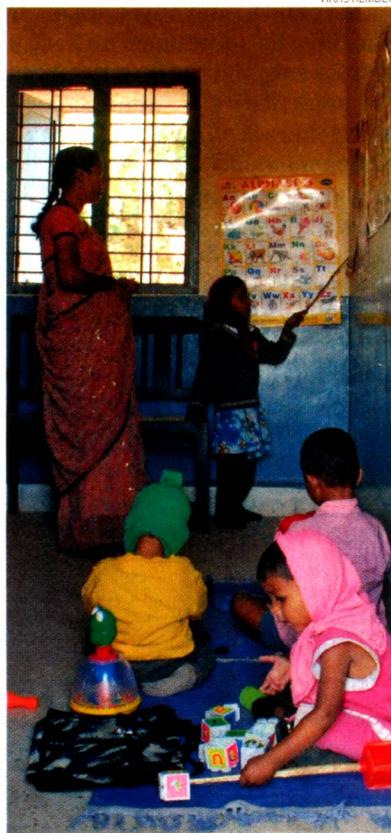


with their problems. Kerala, however, is the only state in India to have a separate wing for reformation and rehabilitation of prisoners. After these children come out of jail, they are perceived as a social stigma and hence find it increasingly difficult to adjust in society. "The child has to start from scratch and the number of years he spent in jail is the number of years by which he lags behind from normal children," says Nanaware. Experts recommend that children be allowed to be taken out of jail often so that they don't remain unaware of the actual world and also that prison authorities should grant parole to women in the last month of pregnancy and till at least a month after delivery.

On the other hand, Arun Kapur, the director of Vasant Valley School in Delhi, has been actively involved in the welfare work of children in Tihar Jail. He founded an organisation, Ritinjali, with a view to fulfilling their basic necessities which are often compromised on in jail. The NGO has



VIRAG REMIGO

SANJANA BALKHANE, 3

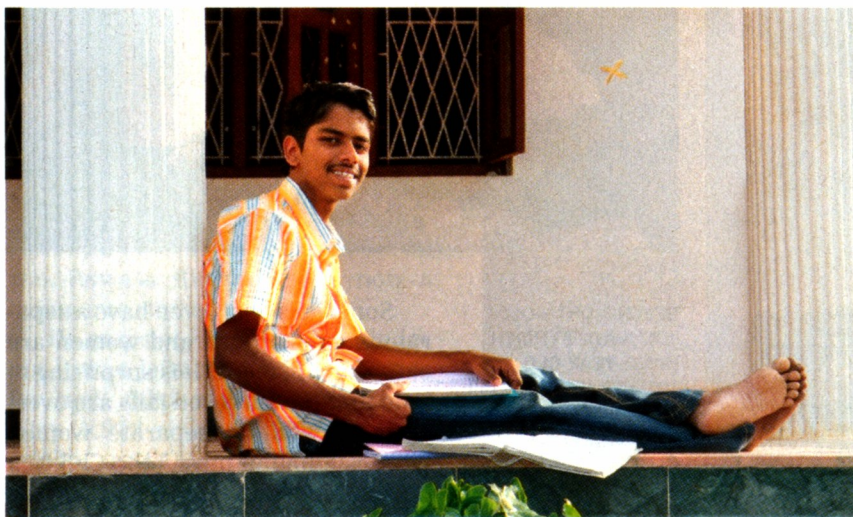
Crime of Mother: Undertrial for murder

Prison: Amravati Central Jail

Case Details: The girl has been living in prison for three months. She hates being caged in jail and constantly nags her mother and crèche teacher to take her out of the prison.

sonal level for a long time. I do it even while managing the school," says Kapur. Not restricting its responsibilities till the children are inside, Ritinjali helps them with clothes and snacks even after they leave Tihar. For the mothers, the NGO provides earning opportunities in jail through jobs like sewing so they can support their children living outside jail. Their core responsibility is to help children directly with their basic needs and rehabilitate their mothers so that it benefits their children indirectly. "We try our best to make life easy for these children who are often victims of people's judgemental attitudes," adds Dipika Nanjappa, secretary of Ritinjali.

Most of the women in prisons belong to the economically and socially backward sections of society who are convicted for murder, mostly committed due to domestic issues. So children who share the ward with them develop a rebellious mindset as they see prisoners being ill-treated in jails. "These are the crucial years since the child has high levels of curiosity and oppositional behaviour. These are traits of a child which need to be utilised properly, however, all this is compromised on in the jail," says clinical psychologist and psychotherapist Dr Narendra Kinger. The influence of prisoners on the minds of growing children is an enormous issue because these children may engage in anti-social behaviour and harm people and property without fear. So by ignoring the reformation of children in jails, we aren't only spoiling the future of hundreds of innocent lives but also producing a factory of future criminals in the country. ■



SENTHIL KUMARAN

RUFUS ANTON, 18

Crime of Mother: Drug peddling

Prison: Trivandrum Jail

Case Details: Rufus was born in Central jail and stayed there for five years with his mother. An NGO, Aswasa Bhavan, in Chennai has taken him in their care after he was released from prison.

been providing story books, summer and winter clothes, brand new toys and snacks to these children for 15 years now. They work in close association with volunteers of India Vision, an NGO founded by former inspector general, Tihar Jail, Kiran Bedi to educate children in the jail through a day-care facility. "I have been involved in this work at a per-